



WORD CLASSES: FUNCTION AND CONTENT WORDS



LEARNING OBJECTIVES

At the end of the lesson, you should be able to:

- Accurately identify and categorise function and content words within given sentences.
- Apply your understanding of function and content words to analyse and deconstruct sentences for syntactic structure.
- Recognise these words not only in isolation but also integrate them appropriately in your own writing, showcasing a deeper understanding of your roles in constructing meaningful sentences.





INTRODUCTION

Function
words

Vs

Content
words



WORD CLASSES

As we have been learning that each word belongs to a part of speech. Also in linguistics (or in language), words can be categorised or classified into two main classes: function words and content words.

These classes are based on the grammatical and semantic roles that words play in sentences.





FUNCTION WORDS

Function words, also known as grammatical words or structure words, are words that have a primarily grammatical function and convey little or no meaning on their own. Instead, they serve to connect or build relationships between content words. Function words are crucial for the grammatical structure of a sentence.

Note, this doesn't mean that function words are completely useless.





FUNCTION WORDS

According to James Pennebaker, "*function words account for less than one-tenth of 1 percent of your vocabulary but make up almost 60 percent of the words you use.*"

Below are other ways function words can be known as:

- ❖ Grammatical morphemes
- ❖ Function morphemes
- ❖ Empty words
- ❖ Structure words
- ❖ Grammatical words
- ❖ Grammatical functors
- ❖ Form words





FUNCTION WORDS

The parts of speech that fall under the category of function words are:

- Conjunctions
- Auxiliary/Helping verbs
- Prepositions
- Articles
- Pronouns

Word examples include:

A, an, and, be, under, the, he, etc.





MORE EXAMPLES

Conjunctions	Helping Verbs	Pronouns	Prepositions	Articles
But	Was	They	Between	A
Although	Been	She	In	An
Since	Has	Them	At	The
So	Have	It	Up	
For	Did	My	Over	

Your turn



Your turn





MORE EXAMPLES

Modals	Qualifiers	Question Words <i>(in some cases)</i>
Can	Very	Who
Could	Quite	Why
May	Too	Where
Should	Much	When
Will	Somewhat	Which

Your turn



Your turn





CONTENT WORDS

Content words, also referred to as lexical words, carry the main meaning in a sentence. They convey information about the real-world or abstract entities, actions, qualities, or relationships. Content words are typically nouns, verbs, adjectives, and adverbs.





CONTENT WORDS

The parts of speech that fall under the category of function words are:

- Nouns
- Verbs
- Adjectives
- Adverbs





MORE EXAMPLES

Nouns	Verbs	Adjectives	Adverbs
Table	Drown	Robust	Quietly
Bag	Dig	Clever	Loudly
Boy	Bury	Abrasive	Irritably
Mountain	Kill	Difficult	Surreptitiously
Plaza	Suffocate	Beautiful	Predictably

Your turn



Your turn





CONTENT WORDS AND FUNCTION WORDS

Recognising the distinction between content and function words holds significance, as emphasis in English conversation is placed on content words, while function words remain non-stressed. Essentially, function words lack emphasis in spoken language, whereas content words are accentuated. Familiarity with this disparity contributes not only to comprehension but also, crucially, to refining pronunciation skills.





SUMMARY

In this lesson on content words and function words, we explored the fundamental distinction between these two linguistic categories. Content words, encompassing nouns, verbs, adjectives, and adverbs, carry the primary meaning of a sentence and are emphasised in communication. On the other hand, function words, including articles, prepositions, conjunctions, pronouns, and certain adverbs, serve structural roles without bearing significant meaning and are typically non-stressed in speech. Understanding this dichotomy is crucial for constructing grammatically correct sentences, enhancing comprehension, and refining pronunciation skills.





CHECK: DID YOU HIT THE TARGET OF THE LESSON?

- ☐ Can you accurately identify and categorise function and content words within given sentences?
- ☐ Can you apply your understanding of function and content words to analyse and deconstruct sentences for syntactic structure?
- ☐ Can you recognise these words not only in isolation but also integrate them appropriately in your own writing?





FURTHER READING

Nordquist, Richard. "Definition and Examples of Function Words in English."

Beare, Kenneth. "Content and Function Words."





THANK
YOU